

We the People of the Fourth World: The Makings of a Song

I decided to attach this small paper in order to outline the process I went through in compiling this project. As a whole, it represents my attempt to amplify the Dene statement of nationhood in 1975 by setting it to original music, along with accompanying pictures of the Dene themselves. As I had never undertaken a project of this sort, it represented a new learning experience: choosing a musical form, identifying appropriate lyrics, and then learning how to record and mix effectively were all new to me. As I listen to the song in retrospect, I am painfully aware that the sound quality is not as good as the sound recorded in a professional studio with a producer. However, I knew this would be a challenge before I started the project, and decided that I would not let this stop me. I have played various musical instruments for most of my life, and this gave me the opportunity to try my hand at actually recording something I had written.

At the Outset

As our class progressed through the history of treaty-making, I initially struggled with what genre of music to use, and what I would write about. In particular, songs are designed to (hopefully) elicit emotional response from a listener, but I was unsure of exactly what type of emotional response I wanted to capture. The ill treatment of aboriginal peoples was motivating me to write a song born out of frustration, with an 'edgier' sound, but then I also wanted to capture a hopeful future. The initial struggle for me was to find a way to reconcile these two different styles of music.

Throughout the semester, fellow classmate Ryan Klausing and I would get together after class on Wednesdays to explore different chords and ideas. At one point in the process, I stumbled upon what I felt was a good combination of chords, and had also started toying with the idea of a spoken word format based on the Great Whale film we had watched in class.

The Dene Declaration

When I read the Dene declaration of 1975 it immediately resonated with me. Powerful frustrations are voiced in the statement, but simultaneously, there is an underlying sense of immense pride coupled with a hopeful outlook for the future (notwithstanding a difficult past). For me, the statement resonated personally. I have studied, worked, and lived in some of the African countries (referred to in the statement) who gained their independence in the wave of decolonization that occurred in the 1960s and 1970s. However, I had never considered the parallels that could be drawn to aboriginal peoples in Canada. At a personal level the reading of the statement shifted my paradigm: why shouldn't the Dene have the right to self governance? Almost immediately I decided that the declaration would serve as the lyrics to my song. Up to that point I had been struggling with writing 'personal' lyrics about experiences that were not mine, with the distinct feeling of being something of an imposter. Using the Dene declaration allowed me to tell the story using the words of the Dene themselves, but in a medium that would amplify its contents.

What's in a Song?

The song is divided into two main themes, verses and choruses. The verses are rooted in an E-minor chord that switches to several varieties of D and A chords. Minor chords can be 'sadder' and are my attempt to capture the power of the declaration, and also the frustrations that are voiced. Conversely, the chorus is a combination of major chords only; D, G, and A that represent the hope in a

positive future. I initially contemplated inserting backing vocals (of other nations that had won independence) into the choruses but abandoned the idea in the mixing phase, because I found that it detracted from allowing the music to speak for itself. In its present form, the chorus is music only for the first half of the song, but is played with vocals present for the second part.

Recording and mixing the song proved to be major hurdles initially, especially since I had no prior experience with the process. I learned that the entire recording industry has undergone a 'so fit were revolution'. Lap tops have replaced massive sound boards, and expensive recording hardware that would have cost tens and even hundreds of thousands of dollars can now be acquired in software format for fractions of that price. Whereas formally each amplifier produced a unique sound and had to be purchased separately, software programs now allow users to select various amplifier sounds directly from the software. As such, I purchased some recording software, a microphone, and a converter that allows one to plug in an instrument directly into a computer and was on my way.

The recording and mixing process itself is a real art in and of itself. Music that sounds great in acoustic form must be captured with just the right amounts of volume for each instrument as it is recorded. This part of the process was the most challenging for me. The song itself has 15 different tracks on it. That is, there are 15 different instrumental sounds that are played (all by me) at different points in the overall recording. These include two types of bells (ringing very faintly at different intervals), three different synthesizer tracks, and of course, drums, vocals and several guitar riffs. Some of the tracks were recorded without difficulty, but others were harder. Surprisingly the vocals, which I had assumed would be the easiest part of the recording, (how hard can it be to read a statement without error and in a certain tone) turned out to be particularly challenging. In failed take after failed take (unbelievably, this figure is upwards of 50), I was unable to capture the desired tone, or would make some small error while recording. (On a purely anecdotal note, the phone ringing, police siren wailing, and dog barking all seemed to occur right at the end of a perfect take). Ultimately, I had to divide the vocals into three different sections because I simply was unable to record it all together in one take and even then, was, and remain slightly unsatisfied with the result.

Slideshow

After recording the song, it occurred to me that a picture slideshow might enhance both the music and the declaration. An online search for pictures of the Dene nation netted the pictures in the slideshow, which I then imported into a power point format for ease of presentation with the music in the background. I also decided to record the song once without the slides, in case they overpowered the actual music.

Conclusions

My father had canoed the Mackenzie River, and as a child I remember flipping through black and white photos of spectacular scenery and fascinating Aboriginal ceremonies, dances, and people. I had forgotten about the photos until we began to study the Mackenzie Valley pipeline inquiry and I realized the photos were of the Dene people and their way of life. I think this was a contributing factor for why the Declaration particularly resonated with me. Here was a people that had been duped, oppressed, and decimated by disease and yet were still proud to stand tall, and declare proudly that they represented the 'fourth world'. As a musician, working on the project gave me the opportunity to really attempt to personally experience their pride, strength and hope in the declaration. With luck, I have been able to convey and perhaps magnify those feelings for others via art.

Hope you enjoy!